

UNSAFE NEW JACKETS

US and NATO standards specify that **BP** jackets must protect soldiers from bullets fired from their own weapons. This recognises the possibility of their weapons falling into the hands of the enemy. The 59,000 jackets now being acquired by the CRPF for anti-Naxal operations are certified at Level III, which means they should be able to stop regular 7.62 mm rounds fired by AK-47 assault rifles. This is the commonest threat perception in places like Jammu and Kashmir where insurgents bring their own weapons and ammunition from across the border. It may not hold true for operations against the Maoists in the Red Corridor.

If police forces fighting Maoists in central India have sleepless nights, it is because of the 'Kirkee round'. Named after the Ordnance Factory in which it is manufactured, the indigenously made 7.62 mm round has a steel core that can shatter the Hard Armour Panel of Level III jackets with fatal consequences for the user. This lethal ammunition was looted in vast quantities by the Maoists from the police and paramilitary forces, together with the INSAS rifle which fires the high-velocity 5.56 mm ammunition. OFB ammunition was used to kill 75 CRPF personnel in the Dantewada Maoist attack this April. While several state police forces have been going in for Level III+ jackets to protect their men from the Kirkee round, the CRPF's new jackets cannot protect its soldiers from this devastating indigenous ammunition. A cruel irony for a force which has been at the receiving end of Maoist attacks in the past few months.

2005 and the Madhya Pradesh Police in 2007. An inquiry was ordered by then defence secretary Shekhar Dutt in the Assam Rifles case but its outcome was never clear. "Such scams raise serious doubts on the effectiveness of jackets that are meant to boost a soldier's confidence," says Harshvir Pratap Sharma, a Supreme Court lawyer who filed a PIL, alleging cartels in the bulletproof jacket trade some years ago.

A senior home ministry official confirms the existence of cartels in the bulletproof jacket trade. "If they don't win a contract, they can go to any extent to subvert, sabotage and pervert the system," he says. It is not clear what is more shocking: that there are firms which will scrimp on a life-saving product or the fact that the Government knows that they are doing so. Some evidence of frantic cartels at work were clear in December last year. Just as the home ministry was shortlisting the finalists in the contract for 59,000 jackets, a CD purported to be a conversation between Verma, a DRDO scientist and joint director at the TBRL, and Anjani's Gupta surfaced. Verma, who was subsequently transferred out of the facility, was heard hinting at the trials being rigged. Crucial ballistic data which would establish how the jackets had

OFB-MANUFACTURED AMMUNITION SEIZED FROM MAOISTS BY THE JHARKHAND POLICE



AP PHOTO

performed in trials had been fudged. "We are, in fact, the whistleblowers and are being made to pay the price for it," an indignant Gupta said, hinting at his role in the sting operation while contesting his remand by the CBI in the Delhi High Court. Home ministry officials say this sting operation was timed to scuttle the entire tendering process and restart it so that companies like Anjani could re-enter the fray.

The MHA instead scrapped the



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